



INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 3

CASTE 2 – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

SANSKRITISATION

1 **Process** whereby members of a (usually middle or lower) caste attempt to raise their own social status by adopting the ritual, domestic and social practices of a caste (or castes) of higher status.

2 **Old phenomenon** but has intensified in recent times.

3 **Usually accompanies** a **rise in the economic status** of the caste attempting it, though it may also occur independently.

3 Also seen as a defiant claiming of previously prohibited ritual/social privileges (such as the wearing of the sacred thread, which used to invite severe punishment) rather than a flattering imitation of the 'upper' castes by the 'lower' castes.

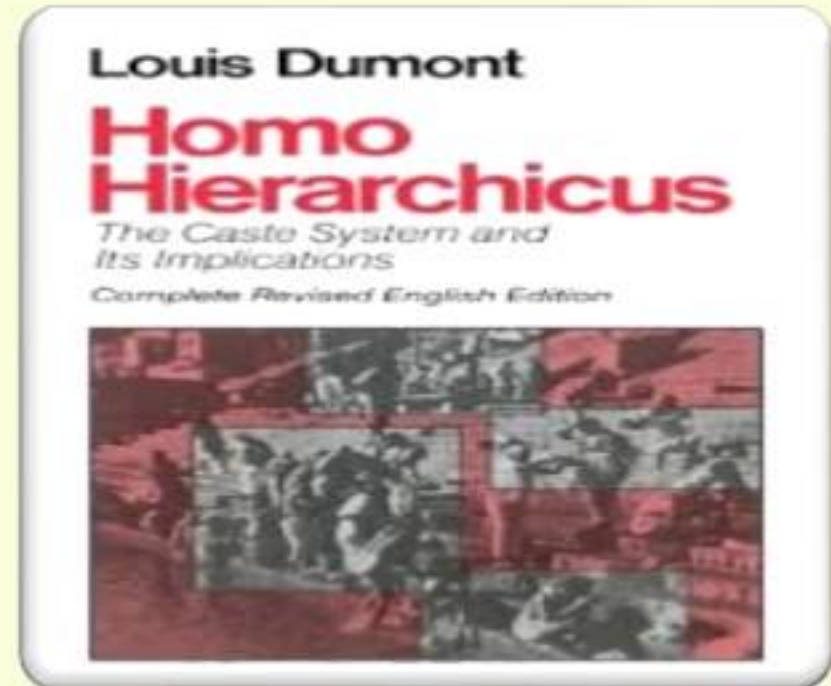


M. N. SRINIVAS

CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

SUBSTANTIALIZATION OF CASTE

- 1**
 - Caste substantialization is a process by which castes separate, distinguish and isolate themselves from each other and from the caste structure.
 - Castes take on independence and individuality by becoming discrete entities of a substantial whole.
- 2** Caste associations undertake many economic and political activities for the benefit of the community members.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

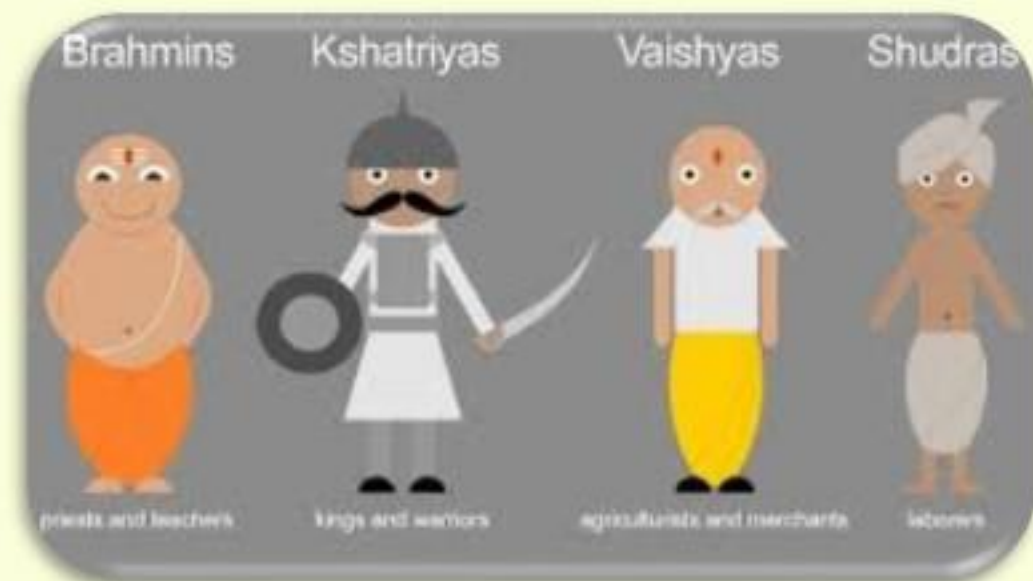
DOMINANT CASTE

1 Those castes which had a large population and were granted land rights (from erstwhile absentee land lords) by the partial land reforms effected after Independence.

2 These intermediate castes in turn depended on the labour of the lower castes including specially the 'untouchable' castes for tilling and tending the land.

3 Once they got land rights, they acquired considerable economic power.

4 Their large numbers also gave them political power in the era of electoral democracy based on universal adult franchise.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

DOMINANT CASTE

- 5** Thus, these intermediate castes became the 'dominant' castes in the country side and played a decisive role in regional politics and the agrarian economy.
- 6** Examples of such dominant castes include
- the Yadavs of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh
 - the Vokkaligas of Karnataka
 - the Reddys and Kammas of Andhra Pradesh
 - the Marathas of Maharashtra
 - the Jats of Punjab, Haryana and Western Uttar Pradesh and
 - the Patidars of Gujarat



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE AND CLASS NEXUS

- 1 In actual historical practice economic and social status tended to coincide.
- 2
 - In modern times, and particularly since the nineteenth century, the link between caste and occupation has become much less rigid.
 - It is easier than before to change one's occupation.
- 3
 - Correlation between caste and economic status is also weaker – rich and poor people are to be found in every caste.

PERCENTAGE OF POPULATION LIVING BELOW THE POVERTY LINE, 2011-12

CASTE AND COMMUNITY GROUPS	RURAL INDIA	URBAN INDIA
	SPENDING RS.327 OR LESS PER PERSON PER MONTH	SPENDING RS.454 OR LESS PER PERSON PER MONTH
Scheduled Tribes	45.3	24.1
Scheduled Castes	31.5	21.7
OBC's	22.7	15.4
UC Muslim	26.9	22.7
UC Hindu	25.6	12.1
UC Christian	22.2	05.5
UC Sikh	06.2	05.0
All Groups	25.4	13.7

Source: Report of NITI Aayog, 2014

CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE AND CLASS NEXUS

- 4 But the caste-class correlation is still remarkably stable at the macro level – mainly between different socio-economic Groupings.
- 5 It is still true that the privileged (and high economic status) sections of society tend to be overwhelmingly 'upper' caste while the disadvantaged (and low economic status) sections are dominated by the so called 'lower' castes.
- 6 With substantialization of caste, caste also functions as class as they operate as interest groups.

PERCENTAGE OF POPULATION THAT IS AFFLUENT, 1999-2000

CASTE AND COMMUNITY GROUPS	RURAL INDIA	URBAN INDIA
	SPENDING RS.1000 OR LESS PER PERSON PER MONTH	SPENDING RS.2000 OR LESS PER PERSON PER MONTH
Scheduled Tribes	1.4	1.8
Scheduled Castes	1.7	0.8
OBC's	3.3	2.0
UC Muslim	2.0	1.6
UC Hindu	8.6	8.2
UC Christian	18.9	17.0
UC Sikh	31.7	15.1
UC Others	17.9	14.4
All Groups	4.3	4.5

Computed from NSSO 55TH Round (1999-2000) unit level data on CD

CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE IN THE PRESENT

RESILIENT CASTE

Recruitment to industrial jobs, whether in the textile mills of Mumbai, the jute mills of Kolkata or elsewhere, **continued to be organised along caste and kinship-based lines.**



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE IN THE PRESENT

CULTURAL AND DOMESTIC SPHERES

- **Endogamy**, or the practice of marrying within the caste, **remained unaffected** by modernisation and change.
- While some boundaries may have become more flexible or porous, the **borders** between groups of castes of similar socio-economic status **are still heavily patrolled**.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE AND POLITICS

- 1 British rule provided founding ground for interaction of caste and politics.
- 2
 - Republican party was formed by Dalit leaders under Ambedkar in 1956 as a political venture to mobilize dalits after independence
 - Political mobilization was viewed as a source of social empowerment.
- 3 Substantialization of caste and Identity politics became two important aspects of caste and politics in contemporary India.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE IN THE PRESENT

POLITICS

- In independent India, democratic politics has been deeply conditioned by caste.
- Since the 1980s there is emergence of explicitly caste-based political parties.
- This includes the rise of intermediate castes.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE IN THE PRESENT

1 Modern industry created all kinds of new jobs for which there were no caste rules.

2 Urbanisation and the conditions of collective living in the cities made it difficult for the caste-segregated patterns of social interaction to survive.

3 Modern educated Indians attracted to the liberal ideas of individualism and meritocracy, began to abandon the more extreme caste practices.

4 For upper caste, urban middle and upper classes, who have benefited the most from the developmental policies of the post-colonial era, caste has appeared to decline in significance.



CASTE – CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CASTE IN THE PRESENT

5 For SCs and STs, caste has become all too visible eclipsing the other dimensions of their identities (no inherited educational and social capital, and they must compete with an already entrenched upper caste group – Reservations became lifeline).

6 Reservations are provided to undo historical injustice that lower castes are subjected to. This is positive discrimination.

7 Juxtaposition of a seemingly caste-less upper caste group and an apparently caste-defined lower caste group – is one of the central aspects of the institution of caste in the present.



AVENUES OF MOBILITY



GANDHI ON CASTE	AMBEDKAR ON CASTE
According to him, Varna Vyavastha was integral to the Hindu social organization, though it needed reforms.	He deemed it as a product of Brahminical distortions and gave the theory of Broken Men to explain the subjugation of untouchables. According to it, untouchables were the people who lost the wars and were merely Broken Men in the beginning.
Gandhi's views on caste evolved slowly over the years, he remained deeply spiritual and sought social change within Hinduism.	Ambedkar had radical views on caste and argued that beliefs of people cannot be altered and, thus, he favored using state as an instrument for establishing forward-thinking social policies.
Gandhi saw solution to untouchability in terms of gradual change of hearts of Hindus.	Ambedkar, on the other hand, envisaged a political economic solution in terms of change of the structure itself.
Gandhi gave untouchables a new name - Harijan - to denote that they are equal children of god.	Ambedkar also rejected Gandhian notion of Harijan as soothing palliative to disguise the hard reality of caste.
According to Gandhi, every work is sacred and the type of work performed by one caste doesn't make it superior or inferior to other castes.	Work assigned to untouchables was not held in similar respect as of other caste's work and it was the most dehumanizing.
He wanted reformation of caste and Hindu society.	Ambedkar wanted annihilation of caste.

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